

AP-3: Silent Conflict Collapse

Derivation Note D3.05 — Phase D3: Anti-Pattern Formalizations

Series D — Paper 3 Derivation Notes | Note #580

Category 2: Conflict Handling Failures (opens this category)

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This work derives from and formalizes the inter-Self coordination architecture introduced in *Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration* (Li, April 2026), the third paper in the CKS theory series following *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems* (Li, April 2026) and *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model* (Li, April 2026).

Abstract

AP-3 formalizes Silent Conflict Collapse, the first of four Conflict Handling Failures (Category 2) in the Phase D3 anti-pattern taxonomy for Paper 3 inter-Self coordination. The anti-pattern occurs when conflicts that arise during Full Aspect Integration (FAI) merge operations are automatically resolved — one side selected, the other discarded — without registering either side as a first-class object in the conflict registry. The merge appears to succeed; the conflict boundary information has been permanently destroyed. This note develops the anti-pattern across seven elements: name and category, description, detection criteria, governance commitments violated, consequences, intra-Self analog, and resolution. The central argument is threefold: (1) detection is the primary governance challenge because the anti-pattern is structurally designed to be invisible; (2) conflict boundary destruction is the primary harm because it permanently erases the intelligence about where participating Selves' governance approaches differ, with no recovery path; and (3) the intra-Self analog at Paper 2 B3.08 (Untracked Conflict Resolution) establishes the prior-art inheritance chain, which this note formally extends to inter-Self scope.

1. Anti-Pattern Name and Category

Name: AP-3 — Silent Conflict Collapse

Category: Taxonomy Category 2 — Conflict Handling Failures. This note opens Category 2. Category 2 covers anti-patterns in which inter-Self conflicts that arise during FAI merge operations are mishandled after they surface — or suppressed before they can surface — in ways that violate

the three-tier conflict-handling mechanism established by Paper 3 Claim 3. Category 1 (Construction and Dissolution Failures) covers structural failures in establishing and dissolving the shared substrate. Category 2 covers operational failures in how conflicts are handled within an otherwise structurally sound inter-Self coordination arrangement. AP-3 is the first and most foundational Category 2 anti-pattern: it describes the failure mode in which conflicts are not merely misrouted or improperly escalated but are collapsed before they can be registered at all.

The name "Silent Conflict Collapse" captures both defining properties. *Collapse* is precise: the conflict that exists between the two contributing Selves' governance approaches collapses into a single outcome — one side silently wins, the other silently disappears — rather than being preserved as the dual-sided object the architecture requires. *Silent* is precise: the collapse produces no trace in the conflict registry, no attribution to contributing aspects, and no governance record. The merge result looks correct. The conflict boundary information is gone.

2. Description

During a Full Aspect Integration event, participating Selves contribute aspects to the shared substrate. When two or more contributed aspects cover overlapping content domains with divergent specifications — when the aspects disagree — a conflict exists. Paper 3 Claim 3, inheriting from Paper 1 Claim 2, establishes the architectural default: that conflict must be detected, registered as a first-class object with both sides preserved, and attributed to its contributing aspects before any routing or resolution decision is made. The conflict is not a problem to be disposed of before proceeding; it is a substrate-level state that carries information about where the participating Selves' governance approaches differ.

Silent Conflict Collapse is the failure mode in which this registration never occurs. Instead of detecting the conflict and registering it, the FAI merge operation resolves it automatically — selecting one contributing aspect's specification and discarding the other — and completes the merge as though no conflict existed. The shared substrate receives a single merged state. The conflict registry receives no entry. The discarded specification leaves no trace. The merge is reported as successful.

The anti-pattern has three structural variants based on what drives the automatic resolution:

Variant A — Default-wins collapse: The merge operation applies a configured default (e.g., most-recent-author wins, alphabetical-first wins, contributing-Self-A-priority) without checking whether any conflict should first be registered. The default rule functions as a silent resolution rule rather than as a post-registration routing rule.

Variant B — LLM-arbitrated collapse: The merge operation delegates conflict detection and resolution to an LLM-mediated step that selects among the contributing specifications and returns a single output. The LLM's selection is accepted as the merge result. No conflict registry entry is created because from the merge operation's perspective, the LLM "resolved" the disagreement before it became a conflict.

Variant C — Intersection-only collapse: The merge operation emits only content on which the contributing aspects agree, silently dropping all divergent content. The merged state is technically consistent — it contains no internal contradictions — but it is incomplete: the governance approaches that differed have been excised rather than preserved.

All three variants share the defining property of AP-3: the conflict boundary information — the record of what the two sides said and that they disagreed — is destroyed without governance authorization.

3. Detection Criteria

Silent Conflict Collapse is the most detection-resistant anti-pattern in Category 2. The preceding category's failures (ungoverned construction, premature dissolution) produce observable structural anomalies: a substrate missing required metadata, a dissolution without proper hand-off. AP-3 produces nothing anomalous at the surface. The merge completes. The shared substrate is internally consistent. The conflict registry is quiet. A governance practitioner reviewing only the merge output has no basis to suspect a problem.

Detection therefore cannot be reactive — waiting for the conflict registry to reveal an error — because the registry contains exactly what the collapsed merge put there: nothing. Detection must be prospective, comparing what should be in the registry against what is there. The following three detection approaches provide governance practitioners with actionable inspection paths.

Detection Approach 1 — Content-Domain Overlap Analysis

Before or after a FAI merge, examine the content domains covered by each contributing aspect. For each pair of contributing aspects, identify whether they cover overlapping domains. Where overlap exists, determine whether the specifications in those domains are divergent. If content-domain overlap with divergent specifications is found, at least one conflict should exist for that merge. Query the conflict registry for entries attributable to that FAI event and those contributing aspects. If the registry has no entries for a merge that should have produced conflicts, AP-3 is presumptively present.

The overlap analysis is most tractable when aspects carry explicit content-domain declarations as substrate content — a governance practice that D2 operational notes establish as a sub-commitment of Claim 2. When content-domain declarations are absent, the overlap analysis requires reading the aspects' substantive content and comparing it directly, which is labor-intensive but auditable.

Detection Approach 2 — Missing-Side Analysis on Merged State

Review the shared substrate content produced by the merge. For each contributing Self's governance approach that was present in their contributed aspect, determine whether that approach is represented in the merged state. If one contributing Self's approach is entirely absent from the merged state — not referenced, not preserved as a conflict entry, not annotated as a carry-through object — without any governance decision authorizing its exclusion, AP-3 may be present. The absence of a governance decision is the critical test: an authorized exclusion (governed by

orchestration rules under joint authority) leaves a record; a silent exclusion leaves nothing.

This approach is most useful when the contributing Selves' aspects are retained as provenance objects in the shared substrate. When aspects are discarded after merge, the comparison requires accessing home-substrate records from contributing Selves, which requires joint-governance cooperation.

Detection Approach 3 — Conflict Registry Completeness Review

Maintain a baseline expectation for conflict registry density: given the typical overlap profile between contributing Selves' aspects, a healthy FAI governance process should produce some minimum rate of conflict registry entries per merge event. A conflict registry that is empty or sparse relative to that baseline — particularly across multiple merge events involving Selves with substantially overlapping content domains — is a statistical signal that AP-3 is systematically present. This approach does not identify specific collapsed conflicts but flags that the registry is structurally underreporting.

Registry completeness review is most effective when FAI events are logged with contributing-aspect provenance, allowing the reviewer to correlate merge event density with registry entry density. An empty registry is not itself conclusive — a FAI event between aspects with entirely non-overlapping domains produces no conflicts legitimately — but an empty registry for Selves whose governance approaches are known to differ on contested dimensions is a strong AP-3 signal.

The Governance Posture Implication

Because silent conflict collapse cannot be detected from the conflict registry alone, governance practitioners operating at inter-Self coordination scope must treat conflict registry completeness as an active audit obligation, not a passive monitoring target. The registry's silence is not evidence of governance health; it is evidence of either genuine non-conflict (confirmed only by content-domain analysis) or AP-3.

4. Governance Commitments Violated

Primary violation — Paper 1 Claim 2 (conflict preservation as first-class substrate state).

Paper 1 Claim 2 establishes that when conflicts are detected within the coordination substrate, both sides must be retained as substrate content; neither side may be silently discarded. This commitment holds at inter-Self scope by inheritance through Paper 3 Claim 1 (the shared substrate carries all six Paper 1 commitments within its perimeter). Silent Conflict Collapse violates this commitment at its foundation: one contributing side is not retained; no side is registered; the conflict is not detected as a substrate-level event at all. The violation is not a partial violation of Claim 2 — it is a complete bypass of the entire preservation pipeline.

Secondary violation — Paper 3 Claim 3 Tier 1 (the preserve tier as architectural default).

Paper 3 Claim 3 establishes the three-tier inter-Self conflict-handling mechanism: preserve, resolve via orchestration, escalate to humans. The preserve tier is the architectural default: conflicts not requiring immediate resolution remain first-class addressable substrate state. The preserve tier's function is not merely to defer resolution — it is to ensure that conflict boundary information enters

the shared substrate as a governable object. Silent Conflict Collapse bypasses the preserve tier entirely. The conflict never enters the three-tier routing mechanism because it is collapsed before it can be detected and registered.

Operational reference — D2.07 (conflict detection at merge). The D2.07 sub-commitment establishes that conflict detection is the first operation of every FAI merge event: conflicts are first-class objects from the moment of detection, not after routing or registration completes. Silent Conflict Collapse fails at this foundational step — the detection protocol does not execute, or executes and suppresses its output rather than propagating it to the registry.

5. Consequences

Consequence 1 — Permanent destruction of conflict boundary information. The governance value of conflict detection during FAI is precisely the intelligence it produces: a record of where the participating Selves' governance approaches differ. This information is not merely procedural. It tells each participating Self what the other Self's approach looks like on contested dimensions, which is the raw material for governance learning at inter-Self scope. Silent Conflict Collapse destroys this intelligence at the point of production. There is no second chance: once the merge completes with no conflict registry entry, the boundary information that existed in the moment of aspect comparison is gone. The contributing aspects may no longer be retained in accessible form. The merge result contains only the surviving side. No downstream process — no audit, no retrospective analysis — can reconstruct what the discarded side said, or that a conflict existed.

This distinguishes AP-3 from governance failures in which a conflict is registered but misrouted, or registered but improperly escalated. Those failures are recoverable: the conflict registry entry exists, both sides are preserved, and governance can intervene to correct the routing. AP-3 is not recoverable. The information is not misplaced; it is destroyed.

Consequence 2 — Determinism contract failure. The determinism contract requires that the merge result be reproducible from governance records alone: given the contributing aspects and the conflict registry, a governed process should be able to reconstruct why the merged state looks the way it does. Silent Conflict Collapse breaks this contract. The merged state exists, but its derivation cannot be reconstructed from governance records because the resolution decision — that one side was selected and one was discarded — was never recorded. The merge result is not auditable.

Consequence 3 — Unauthorized discarding of a contributing Self's governance approach. Each participating Self contributes aspects to the FAI event under the joint governance arrangement of the shared substrate. That arrangement carries an implicit commitment: no contributing Self's governance approach will be discarded without a governance decision authorizing the exclusion. Silent Conflict Collapse violates this commitment. One Self's approach is discarded without any governance process, without any attribution, and without any notification. The affected Self has no basis to know that their contribution was discarded — the merge reported success. This is a contribution-rights violation at the inter-Self governance scope.

Consequence 4 — Governance trust calibration undermined. Participating Selves that cannot verify how their contributions were handled cannot calibrate their trust in the FAI governance process. A Self that contributed an aspect covering contested governance dimensions — and observes that the merged state reflects only the other Self's approach — has no way to determine whether a legitimate governance decision authorized the exclusion or whether AP-3 silently collapsed the conflict. This ambiguity progressively erodes the trust that makes inter-Self coordination viable. Governance trust calibration (D2.29) depends on the conflict registry's completeness. AP-3 systematically undermines that completeness.

Consequence 5 — Evolution feed poisoned at source. Paper 3 Claim 4 establishes that conflicts preserved in the shared substrate carry through as evolution-feed annotations to participating Selves' home substrates. The carry-through mechanism (D1.16) requires that conflict registry entries exist to carry. Silent Conflict Collapse eliminates the source material. No conflict registry entries exist to become evolution-feed annotations. The home substrates of participating Selves receive a merged state but no information about the governance disagreements that existed during the merge. The evolutionary learning that inter-Self coordination is designed to produce does not occur.

6. Intra-Self Analog

Paper 2 B3.08 — Untracked Conflict Resolution

Within a single Self, conflicts can arise during mating operations between aspects at multiple levels of the Self's internal composition. Paper 2 establishes the conflict registry as a sub-commitment of the intra-Self coordination architecture: when conflicts arise during mating, both sides are registered with provenance attribution, and routing proceeds through the governance mechanism. B3.08 formalizes the intra-Self failure mode in which conflicts arising during mating are resolved without entering the conflict registry — one side is selected, the merge proceeds, and the registry receives no entry.

The structural identity between B3.08 and AP-3 is complete. Both describe automatic resolution of a detected or detectable conflict, followed by discarding of one side, followed by completion of the merge with no registry entry and no governance record. The scope differs — B3.08 operates within the perimeter of a single Self across its internal levels; AP-3 operates across the inter-Self perimeter between distinct Selves' governance structures — but the failure mechanism is the same: the conflict detection protocol does not produce a registry entry, and the resulting merge cannot be audited or reproduced from governance records.

This scope extension is the inheritance closure this note formalizes. B3.08 established the prior art for untracked conflict resolution at intra-Self scope. AP-3 applies the same formalization to inter-Self scope. The extension is not merely definitional: at inter-Self scope, the consequences are compounded by the contribution-rights dimension (one Self's approach is discarded without that Self's awareness or governance authorization) and the evolution-feed dimension (carry-through annotations require registry entries that AP-3 ensures will not exist). The intra-Self consequences of B3.08 are recoverable within a single governance perimeter; the inter-Self consequences of AP-3

involve multiple organizational governance structures and may not be recoverable within any single governance arrangement.

The trilogy-level pattern the B3.08 — AP-3 inheritance traces is: every scope at which the CKS architecture specifies a conflict detection and registration protocol has a corresponding silent-collapse anti-pattern. Paper 1 Claim 2 establishes the protocol at cell scope; Paper 2 B3.08 extends it to intra-Self scope and identifies the collapse failure mode; Paper 3 AP-3 extends it to inter-Self scope. The failure mode is structurally invariant across scope; the consequences scale with scope.

7. Resolution

The resolution for AP-3 is not a new architectural mechanism — it is correct application of the governance protocol that Paper 3 already specifies.

D2.07 — Conflict detection at merge as the foundational commitment. D2.07 establishes that conflict detection is the first operation of every FAI merge event, prior to any resolution or routing action. Detection is not optional and cannot be bypassed by a configured default, an LLM-mediated arbitration step, or an intersection-only merge strategy. When content-domain overlap with divergent specifications is identified during a merge, a conflict registry entry must be created before the merge operation proceeds. The detection protocol produces the registry entry as its output; the merge continues only after the registry entry exists.

D2.13 — The seven-field conflict registry entry structure. D2.13 specifies the minimum required fields for a conflict registry entry: (1) conflict identifier, (2) FAI event reference, (3) contributing aspect references for each side, (4) content-domain specification of the conflict, (5) both sides' specifications preserved verbatim, (6) timestamp of detection, and (7) routing-status field initialized to "unrouted." The seven-field structure is what makes the conflict registerable: it captures both sides with full provenance attribution, in a form that the three-tier routing mechanism can operate on and that downstream audit can reconstruct from. A merge implementation that cannot produce seven-field registry entries for detected conflicts is not implementing the governance protocol; it is implementing a protocol that will silently collapse conflicts when the registry-write step fails.

D2.51 — Three-tier routing as the post-registration governance path. Once a conflict is registered per D2.07 and D2.13, the three-tier routing mechanism (D2.51) governs what happens next. Tier 1 (preserve): the conflict remains in the registry as first-class state, with both sides accessible and carry-through annotations enabled. Tier 2 (resolve via orchestration): when prebuilt orchestration rules in the shared substrate cover the conflict class, the rules execute to determine the merge outcome, and the resolution is recorded in the registry entry. Tier 3 (escalate to humans): when no governing orchestration rule covers the conflict class, the conflict surfaces to the joint governance authority of the participating Selves for human decision. In all three tiers, the registry entry exists before the tier is selected. The tier selection does not determine whether the conflict is registered; it determines what happens to an already-registered conflict.

Governance audit commitment as ongoing obligation. Because AP-3 is detection-resistant, resolution is not only a matter of implementing the correct FAI merge protocol. It also requires an ongoing governance audit commitment: periodic content-domain overlap analysis against the conflict registry, registry completeness review relative to merge event volume, and — when AP-3 is suspected — joint audit across participating Selves' provenance records to identify whether missing-side analysis reveals unexplained absences. The detection criteria in §3 of this note define the audit scope. Implementing D2.07, D2.13, and D2.51 correctly prevents future AP-3 occurrences; the audit commitment is what surfaces past occurrences and assesses the extent of conflict boundary information that may have been permanently lost.

Cross-References

- **Paper 3 Claim 3** (three-tier inter-Self conflict-handling mechanism) — primary governance commitment whose Tier 1 (preserve) is bypassed by AP-3
 - **Paper 1 Claim 2** (conflict preservation as first-class substrate state) — foundational commitment violated at inter-Self scope by AP-3
 - **Paper 2 B3.08** (Untracked Conflict Resolution) — intra-Self analog; prior art this note formally extends to inter-Self scope
 - **D2.07** (conflict detection at merge) — operational sub-commitment establishing detection as prerequisite to any routing action
 - **D2.13** (seven-field conflict registry entry structure) — the registration format that makes a conflict a first-class governable object
 - **D2.51** (three-tier routing) — the post-registration governance mechanism that operates on correctly registered conflicts
 - **D1.16** (carry-through annotations for conflict evolution feed) — the downstream mechanism that AP-3 deprives of source material
 - **D2.29** (governance trust calibration) — the trust-accounting sub-commitment AP-3 systematically undermines
 - **D2.66** (determinism contract) — the reproducibility commitment whose failure is a direct consequence of AP-3
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Source Papers

Li, W. (2026). *Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

Li, W. (2026). *The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model: Extending the Coordination Knowledge Substrate Pattern to AI Selves under Human Governance*. April 2026. ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235.

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